

SUMMER INTERNSHIP PROJECT (SIP) – 2025

Summer Internship Project Report submitted to the Malaysia University of Science and Technology, in partial fulfilment of the requirements to award the degree of

MASTER OF BUSINESS ADMINISTRATION

SUBMITTED BY

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CERTIFICATE

This is to certify that the Summer Internship Project Report is an authentic record of Ms. Jayasubha S (OSI2511007) carried out at M/s Ashok Leyland Limited in partial fulfilment of the requirements for the award of the MBA degree.

The project was completed under the guidance of the Human Resources & Industrial Relations Department, Ashok Leyland Limited, during the period of the eight-week internship undertaken in 2025.

Mr. A. Ranjith Kumar

Principal

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Viva Voce Examination Conducted on: _____

Internal Examiner

External Examiner

DECLARATION

I, Ms. Jayasubha S, hereby declare that this SIP Project Report is based on my two months' internship undertaken at M/s Ashok Leyland Limited, as a Human Resources Intern, under the guidance of the Human Resources & Industrial Relations team, Ashok Leyland Limited, and the Indian School of Science and Management, Chennai.

I further declare that this report is my own original work and has not been submitted, in full or in part, for the award of any other degree, diploma, fellowship or similar title of this or any other institution.

Place: Chennai

Date:

Signature

ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

I have undergone extensive learning to complete this internship. However, it would not have been possible without the support and encouragement of many individuals. I take this opportunity to express my sincere gratitude to everyone who guided and supported me through this internship period.

I would like to express my sincere gratitude to our respected Chairman, Mr. KATHIRVEL GANAPATHIAPPAN, for providing us the valuable opportunity to undertake and complete this project.

I express my heartfelt thanks to our visionary, dedicated and empowering Founder and Managing Director, Dr. PARKAVI MAHALINGAM, for her continuous support and meaningful guidance, which played a key role in my progress.

I am highly indebted to our Principal, Mr. A. RANJITH KUMAR, for his guidance, constant supervision, and support in providing the necessary information regarding the project.

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My sincere gratitude goes to the Human Resources & Industrial Relations team at M/s ASHOK LEYLAND LIMITED for mentoring me and offering immense support, exposure and knowledge throughout my internship, and for patiently introducing me to the practical realities of HR and Industrial Relations in a large manufacturing organisation.

Finally, I would like to thank my family and friends for their constant encouragement and motivation throughout this internship and the preparation of this report.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The Summer Internship at M/s Ashok Leyland Limited was an enriching and career-shaping experience that provided direct exposure to the practical functioning of Human Resources and Industrial Relations within a large, unionised manufacturing environment. Spanning eight weeks, the internship focused on understanding the structure and functioning of the HR department, gaining exposure to modern HR technology platforms, contributing to HR analytics and MIS reporting, supporting Industrial Relations documentation, assisting with internal communication and event coordination, exploring Learning & Development systems, and presenting on contemporary themes at the intersection of Artificial Intelligence, leadership and the future of automobile manufacturing.

The internship began with an organisational induction that introduced the intern to Ashok Leyland's corporate structure, its position as the flagship commercial vehicle manufacturer of the Hinduja Group, and the fundamentals of Industrial Relations, including the importance of maintaining a healthy and constructive employer-employee relationship on the shop floor and in the corporate office. Building on this foundation, the intern was exposed to Ashok Leyland's Recruitment Process Outsourcing (RPO) model and the Darwinbox Human Resource Management System (HRMS), gaining an appreciation of how technology has transformed talent acquisition and employee lifecycle management in a large industrial enterprise.

A significant part of the internship involved HR analytics and reporting, where the intern prepared the monthly Industrial Relations Management Information System (IR MIS) report and contributed to the development of a data-driven Employee Relations dashboard. This experience underscored the growing importance of data in HR decision-making. The intern also contributed to a knowledge-management initiative by helping prepare an Industrial Relations reference handbook intended for fresh employees and HR professionals, reinforcing the value of structured documentation in a compliance-sensitive function such as IR.

In the later stages of the internship, the intern was involved in HR communication and event coordination, designing the flyer and agenda for the EFSI (Employers' Federation of Southern India) Conference, and explored the automated Learning & Development dashboard used to track training interventions across the organisation. The internship culminated in two structured presentations — one on 'AI in Leadership and Decision Making' and another on 'Current and Future Trends in Industrial and Automobile Manufacturing' — both of which required secondary research, synthesis and confident articulation of ideas before the HR team.

Through this journey, the intern gained a comprehensive understanding of how a modern HR and Industrial Relations function operates within a heavy manufacturing organisation of Ashok Leyland's scale, and how HR technology, analytics, documentation, communication and continuous learning together sustain a productive and compliant workplace. The internship connected academic learning in Human Resource Management, Organisational Behaviour and Industrial Relations with real corporate practice, offering insights that extend well beyond textbook theory.

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LIST OF ABBREVIATIONS

Abbreviation	Full Form
HR	Human Resources
IR	Industrial Relations
HRMS	Human Resource Management System
MIS	Management Information System
RPO	Recruitment Process Outsourcing
L&D	Learning & Development
EFSI	Employers' Federation of Southern India
CV	Commercial Vehicle
LCV	Light Commercial Vehicle
EV	Electric Vehicle
SIP	Summer Internship Project
MBA	Master of Business Administration

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CHAPTER 1

INDUSTRY AND COMPANY OVERVIEW

1.1 GLOBAL AUTOMOTIVE AND COMMERCIAL VEHICLE LANDSCAPE

The global automotive industry, and the commercial vehicle (CV) segment in particular, is undergoing a period of substantial transformation driven by electrification, digitalisation, tightening emission norms and evolving customer expectations around total cost of ownership. Commercial vehicles — trucks, buses and light commercial vehicles — form the backbone of freight movement and public transportation worldwide, and manufacturers are increasingly expected to deliver not just vehicles but complete mobility solutions encompassing financing, telematics, fleet management and after-sales support.

Alongside the shift in products, the people-management practices of large manufacturing organisations are themselves being reshaped. Human Resource functions in global automotive companies are moving from transactional administration towards strategic workforce planning, skills-based hiring, data-driven Employee Relations and continuous learning ecosystems. At the same time, Industrial Relations continues to occupy a central place in manufacturing-heavy organisations, where large unionised workforces, shop-floor productivity and statutory compliance intersect. Effective IR practice is no longer limited to grievance handling and wage settlements; it now includes proactive engagement, structured communication, and data-backed monitoring of workplace harmony.

The adoption of Human Resource Management Systems (HRMS) such as Darwinbox, SAP SuccessFactors and Workday has accelerated across manufacturing firms, enabling real-time visibility into recruitment pipelines, attendance, performance and training. Recruitment Process Outsourcing (RPO) models have also gained traction, allowing large organisations to scale hiring efficiently while retaining control over quality and employer branding. Together, these shifts mean that HR and IR professionals today require a blend of interpersonal skill, analytical capability and technological fluency.

1.1.1 The Growing Strategic Weight of HR Technology in Automotive Manufacturing

As automotive manufacturers scale their operations across multiple plants and geographies, the ability to manage workforce data consistently and in real time has become a competitive necessity rather than a convenience. Cloud-based HRMS platforms allow organisations to standardise processes such as onboarding, leave management, performance tracking and compliance documentation across plants that may otherwise follow inconsistent local practices. This standardisation is particularly valuable in Industrial Relations, where consistency in how grievances are logged, escalated and resolved directly affects both compliance risk and employee trust.

Global automotive players have also begun applying predictive analytics to workforce planning — for instance, forecasting attrition risk in specific plants, or identifying shifts and departments where overtime patterns may signal capacity strain. While such advanced analytics were beyond the scope of this internship, the exposure gained to MIS reporting and dashboard-building represents a foundational step toward this more predictive, technology-enabled model of HR practice.

1.2 THE INDIAN COMMERCIAL VEHICLE AND MANUFACTURING CONTEXT

India is among the largest commercial vehicle markets in the world, underpinned by robust infrastructure spending, growth in e-commerce logistics, and government initiatives such as the scrappage policy and production-linked incentive (PLI) schemes for automobiles and auto components. Indian CV manufacturers operate large, often unionised, manufacturing workforces spread across multiple plants, making Industrial Relations a strategically important function rather than a purely administrative one.

Government programmes such as Make in India and Digital India have encouraged manufacturers to modernise both their production processes and their people practices, driving investment in automation on the shop floor as well as in digital HR platforms in the corporate office. Compliance-heavy regulatory frameworks — the Industrial Disputes Act, the Factories Act, and more recently the consolidated Labour Codes — require HR and IR teams to maintain meticulous documentation, structured escalation mechanisms and constant dialogue with employee representative bodies and trade unions.

Within this context, large Indian manufacturing conglomerates increasingly view HR analytics, structured knowledge management (handbooks, SOPs, reference guides) and internal communication as critical enablers of both compliance and culture. This is the operating environment within which Ashok Leyland's HR and Industrial Relations function was observed during the internship.

1.3 COMPANY OVERVIEW: ASHOK LEYLAND LIMITED

1.3.1 Background and Corporate Identity

Ashok Leyland Limited, originally established as Ashok Motors in 1948 and renamed Ashok Leyland in 1955 following a technical collaboration with British Leyland, is headquartered at Sardar Patel Road, Chennai, Tamil Nadu. It is the flagship company of the Hinduja Group and stands among India's largest and most respected commercial vehicle manufacturers, with a manufacturing footprint spanning multiple countries including India and the UAE.

Ashok Leyland is the second-largest manufacturer of commercial vehicles in India and ranks among the top global manufacturers of buses and trucks. The company's product portfolio spans heavy, medium and light commercial vehicles, buses (including electric buses under the Switch Mobility brand), defence and military vehicles, engines, and power solutions. It is also the largest supplier of mobility and logistics solutions to the Indian Army, reflecting its deep engineering capability and long-standing institutional relationships.

The company is led by Chairman Mr. Dheeraj G. Hinduja, with Mr. Shenu Agarwal serving as Managing Director and CEO. Ashok Leyland reported record financial performance for FY 2024-25, with profit after tax rising sharply year-on-year and improving EBITDA margins, reflecting resilient demand in the domestic commercial vehicle cycle and disciplined cost management.

1.3.2 Products and Business Segments

- Trucks — Haulage vehicles, tippers and tractor-trailers serving logistics, mining and construction sectors, ranging from light to heavy-duty applications.
- Buses — City buses, intercity coaches and school buses; Ashok Leyland pioneered India's first double-decker bus and continues to be a leading bus body-builder and chassis manufacturer.
- Light Commercial Vehicles (LCVs) — The Dost, Bada Dost, Partner and MiTR range, targeted at small businesses, last-mile delivery and intra-city logistics.

- Defence and Military Vehicles — A significant supplier to the Indian Army and allied defence establishments, leveraging decades of engineering expertise in rugged, mission-critical vehicles.
- Electric and Alternative Fuel Mobility — EV buses and light commercial vehicles under the Switch Mobility brand, along with CNG and LNG-powered trucks as part of the Group's green mobility roadmap.
- Power Solutions and Engines — Diesel and alternative-fuel engines for automotive and industrial applications, including gensets and marine engines.
- Financial Services — Vehicle financing through Hinduja Leyland Finance, supporting customers across the vehicle ownership lifecycle.

1.3.3 Vision, Mission and Strategic Direction

Ashok Leyland's stated ambition is to become one of the world's leading commercial vehicle manufacturers by proactively responding to industry shifts such as electrification, alternative fuel adoption (LNG and hydrogen), digitalisation of fleet management, and evolving global trade dynamics. In the company's Annual Report for 2024-25, Chairman Mr. Dheeraj Hinduja emphasised continued investment in research and development for electric, LNG and hydrogen-powered vehicles, strategic partnerships with technology firms, and deeper penetration into export markets such as the Middle East, Africa and ASEAN through regional manufacturing and supply chains.

Internally, this strategic direction translates into a workforce transformation agenda: building capability in new-age skills (EV powertrains, connected-vehicle software, data analytics), strengthening leadership pipelines, and modernising HR systems so that talent acquisition, engagement and development keep pace with the company's technological ambitions.

1.3.4 Human Resources and Industrial Relations Function

Given the scale of its manufacturing operations across multiple plants, Ashok Leyland's HR function is organised to address both corporate/managerial HR (recruitment, HRMS administration, learning and development, HR analytics, communication) and plant-level Industrial Relations (union engagement, grievance redressal, compliance with labour statutes, wage settlements and workplace harmony initiatives). The IR function works closely with plant leadership and employee representative bodies to sustain productive shop-floor relationships, while the corporate HR team focuses on employer branding, digital HR platforms and organisation-wide people analytics.

During the internship, exposure was gained to both dimensions of this function — the technology-enabled, analytics-oriented side of corporate HR (Darwinbox HRMS, RPO recruitment, MIS dashboards) and the documentation- and communication-intensive side of Industrial Relations (IR MIS reporting, the IR reference handbook, and internal HR communication for events such as the EFSI Conference).

1.3.5 Manufacturing Footprint and Plant Network

Ashok Leyland operates a network of manufacturing plants spread across India, complemented by an assembly facility in Ras Al Khaimah, UAE, giving the company a combined manufacturing footprint across multiple countries. This multi-plant structure is a key reason why Industrial Relations occupies such a strategically important place within the company's HR function: each plant maintains its own local workforce, union dynamics and production rhythms, while corporate HR is responsible for ensuring consistency in policy application, statutory compliance and reporting standards across all locations.

For HR and IR professionals, this multi-plant structure means that centrally designed systems — such as the Darwinbox HRMS and the IR MIS reporting framework observed during this internship — play a critical role in giving corporate leadership a consolidated, comparable view of workforce indicators across otherwise geographically and culturally distinct plant locations.

1.4 SWOT ANALYSIS

1.4.1 Strengths

- **Market Leadership:** Second-largest commercial vehicle manufacturer in India with a diversified product portfolio spanning trucks, buses, LCVs and defence vehicles.
- **Strong Parentage:** Backing of the Hinduja Group provides financial stability, global reach and access to diversified expertise across sectors.
- **Deep Defence Relationships:** Position as the largest supplier of mobility solutions to the Indian Army provides a stable, high-value business segment.
- **Extensive Distribution and Service Network:** A well-established pan-India dealer, service and driver-training network (having trained over 800,000 drivers) strengthens customer relationships and brand loyalty.
- **Progressive HR Technology Adoption:** Implementation of platforms such as Darwinbox HRMS and structured RPO partnerships reflects a forward-looking approach to talent management.

1.4.2 Weaknesses

- **Cyclicalities of the CV Business:** Revenues remain closely tied to the domestic commercial vehicle replacement and infrastructure cycle, exposing the company to periodic demand slowdowns.
- **Complex Industrial Relations Environment:** A large, multi-plant unionised workforce increases the administrative and relational complexity of maintaining industrial harmony.
- **Relatively Slower EV Scale-Up:** Compared to some global peers, the transition of the core CV portfolio to electric and alternative-fuel platforms is still maturing.

1.4.3 Opportunities

- **Export Market Expansion:** Significant growth potential in the Middle East, Africa and ASEAN markets through regional manufacturing partnerships.
- **Electrification and Alternative Fuels:** Rising government and customer emphasis on EV, LNG and hydrogen-powered commercial vehicles opens new product and skill areas.
- **HR Analytics and Digital Transformation:** Continued investment in HRMS and dashboard-based reporting can further improve workforce planning, engagement and compliance monitoring.
- **Infrastructure-Led Demand:** Government investment in roads, logistics parks and public transport is expected to sustain medium-term CV demand.

1.4.4 Threats

- **Intensifying Competition:** Aggressive competition from Tata Motors, Mahindra & Mahindra, VE Commercial Vehicles (Eicher-Volvo) and Daimler India Commercial Vehicles (BharatBenz).

- Regulatory and Compliance Pressure: Evolving labour codes, emission norms and safety regulations require continuous adaptation of both operations and HR/IR processes.
- Talent Competition for New-Age Skills: Rising demand for EV, data analytics and software talent across the automotive sector intensifies competition for scarce specialised talent.
- Macroeconomic Sensitivity: Interest rate movements, fuel price volatility and freight rate fluctuations can dampen commercial vehicle purchase decisions.

1.5 KEY COMPETITORS

Company	Core Segment	Key Focus Area
Tata Motors	Commercial & Passenger Vehicles	Market leadership across CV and PV segments; strong EV push
Mahindra & Mahindra	LCVs, Tractors, SUVs	Rural and semi-urban logistics, farm and utility vehicles
VE Commercial Vehicles (Eicher-Volvo)	Trucks and Buses	Premium and fuel-efficient heavy trucks; Volvo technology
Daimler India Commercial Vehicles (BharatBenz)	Trucks	Technology-driven heavy trucks for domestic and export markets
SML Isuzu	LCVs and Buses	Niche light commercial vehicle and school bus segment

1.6 KEY MILESTONES

1948 — Foundation

Ashok Leyland was founded as Ashok Motors in Chennai, initially set up to assemble vehicles for the Indian market, marking the beginning of what would become one of India's most enduring commercial vehicle manufacturing enterprises.

1955 — Formation of Ashok Leyland

Following a technical collaboration with British Leyland, the company was renamed Ashok Leyland, gaining access to British engineering expertise that would shape its early truck and bus platforms.

1987 — International Expansion

Ashok Leyland commenced its international expansion, extending its commercial presence beyond India's borders and laying the groundwork for what is today a multi-country manufacturing and distribution footprint.

2000s Onward — Product Diversification

The company diversified significantly during this period, expanding into light commercial vehicles through the Dost range, deepening its defence mobility business, and growing its power solutions and engines division to serve both automotive and industrial customers.

2017 Onward — Digital and Electric Transformation

Ashok Leyland accelerated its investment in electric mobility through the Switch Mobility brand, while simultaneously modernising its internal HR and operational systems — a transformation that directly

shaped the technology-enabled HR environment (Darwinbox, RPO, automated dashboards) observed during this internship.

2024-25 — Record Financial Performance

The company reported record annual revenue and profitability, approved a 1:1 bonus share issuance for shareholders, and continued to expand its alternative-propulsion product range, including EV, LNG and hydrogen-powered vehicles, reinforcing its ambition to become a leading global commercial vehicle manufacturer.

1.6.1 Competitor Profiles

Tata Motors remains Ashok Leyland's largest domestic rival, benefiting from scale advantages across both commercial and passenger vehicle segments and an aggressive push into electric mobility across its product range. Its scale allows for significant R&D investment, though this is spread across a wider and more diverse portfolio than Ashok Leyland's more focused commercial vehicle and defence specialisation.

Mahindra & Mahindra competes primarily in the light commercial vehicle and rural mobility space, leveraging its strength in tractors and utility vehicles to serve small-business and agricultural logistics customers — a segment adjacent to, but distinct from, Ashok Leyland's core medium and heavy commercial vehicle strength.

VE Commercial Vehicles, a joint venture between Eicher Motors and the Volvo Group, competes chiefly in the premium and fuel-efficient heavy truck segment, drawing on Volvo's global engineering standards. Daimler India Commercial Vehicles, through its BharatBenz brand, similarly targets the technology-forward segment of the domestic and export truck market, positioning itself on build quality and total cost of ownership.

SML Isuzu occupies a smaller, more specialised niche in light commercial vehicles and school buses, competing on relationship-driven regional sales rather than scale. Collectively, these competitors define a market in which Ashok Leyland must continuously balance cost competitiveness, technological modernisation and its differentiated defence and driver-training strengths.

1.7 COMPETITIVE POSITIONING

Ashok Leyland's competitive positioning rests on its combination of engineering depth, an extensive service and driver-training network, a diversified product base spanning civilian and defence mobility, and the financial and strategic backing of the Hinduja Group. Unlike smaller regional players, Ashok Leyland is able to invest simultaneously in electrification, alternative fuels and digital HR transformation, allowing it to modernise its workforce practices even as it modernises its products.

Compared to Tata Motors, which enjoys scale advantages across both passenger and commercial vehicles, Ashok Leyland differentiates itself through deeper specialisation in medium and heavy commercial vehicles and a uniquely strong defence mobility franchise. Against VE Commercial Vehicles and Daimler India, which lean heavily on foreign technology partnerships for premium positioning, Ashok Leyland leverages its long domestic manufacturing heritage, cost-competitive engineering and an expansive pan-India distribution and driver-training network built over more than seven decades.

For an HR intern, this environment offered a valuable vantage point: observing how a large, engineering-led manufacturing organisation balances the discipline required for statutory Industrial Relations compliance with the innovation required to modernise recruitment, analytics and learning systems for a workforce spread across multiple plants and functions.

1.7.1 Industry Challenges from an HR and IR Perspective

Large commercial vehicle manufacturers such as Ashok Leyland face a distinct set of people-management challenges compared to purely white-collar organisations. Manufacturing operations require careful shift-planning, adherence to statutory working-hour limits, and continuous engagement with unions or employee representative bodies to prevent disruptions to production. Seasonal demand cycles in the CV industry can also create workforce-planning challenges, requiring HR teams to balance permanent, contractual and temporary staffing in a manner that is both compliant and cost-effective.

In addition, the ongoing shift toward electrification and connected-vehicle technology is creating a parallel need for reskilling within the existing workforce, as traditional diesel-engine expertise must be supplemented with knowledge of electric powertrains, battery systems and software-enabled vehicle features. HR and Industrial Relations teams are therefore increasingly involved not only in maintaining current workplace harmony, but also in planning the workforce transition required for the industry's technological future — a theme that was directly explored in the Week 8 presentation on industry trends during this internship.

1.8 FINANCIAL SNAPSHOT AND RECENT PERFORMANCE

Ashok Leyland delivered a record financial performance for the financial year 2024-25, reflecting resilient demand in the domestic commercial vehicle replacement cycle, improved operating leverage and disciplined cost management across its manufacturing plants. The table below summarises key financial indicators reported for the period.

Particulars	FY 2024-25
Revenue	Approx. ₹45,931 crore (US\$ 4.8 billion)
Profit After Tax	₹3,303 crore (up 26% year-on-year)
EBITDA Margin	12.7% (up from 12.0% in FY24)
Total Assets	Approx. ₹67,660 crore
Employee Strength	Approx. 9,695 (2025)
Corporate Action	1:1 bonus share issuance approved by the Board

This performance was accompanied by continued investment in the company's alternate-propulsion portfolio — including EV buses under the Switch Mobility brand, and exploration of LNG and hydrogen technologies — as well as strong contributions from the power solutions and defence business segments. For the HR and IR function, sustained financial strength translates into the ability to invest in HR technology upgrades, structured Learning & Development programmes and competitive employee engagement initiatives, all of which were visible during the course of the internship.

1.9 ORGANISATIONAL CULTURE AND EMPLOYEE VALUE PROPOSITION

Ashok Leyland's workplace culture reflects its identity as a heritage engineering organisation that is actively modernising. The company combines a strong emphasis on safety, discipline and process rigour on the shop floor — essential in a heavy manufacturing environment — with an increasingly employee-centric approach in its corporate functions, including flexible HR service delivery through the Darwinbox self-service portal, structured induction programmes for new joiners, and visible leadership communication during company-wide events such as the EFSI Conference.

The organisation places significant emphasis on driver training and community engagement (having trained over 800,000 drivers since inception), reflecting a broader culture of skill-building that extends even beyond its direct workforce. Internally, cross-functional exposure is encouraged, and interns and new employees are given structured opportunities to rotate across HR sub-functions, as reflected in the design of this very internship programme, which moved the intern sequentially through induction, recruitment, analytics, documentation, communication, learning and development, and strategic research.

This blend of engineering discipline and progressive HR practice creates a distinctive employee value proposition: employees are expected to uphold rigorous compliance and quality standards, while being supported by increasingly digital, data-informed and communicative HR systems.

1.10 RECENT STRATEGIC INITIATIVES

- Electrification and Alternative Fuels: Continued expansion of the EV bus portfolio under Switch Mobility, alongside active exploration of LNG and hydrogen-powered commercial vehicles.
- Export Market Deepening: Strategic focus on the Middle East, Africa and ASEAN markets, supported by regional manufacturing and supply-chain partnerships, including an investment in Optare PLC in the United Kingdom.
- Technology Partnerships: Joint ventures with global technology players such as Continental AG for automotive infotronics, and the Alteams Group for high-pressure die-casting components, reflecting the company's push toward advanced engineering capability.
- Digital HR Transformation: Ongoing investment in platforms such as Darwinbox HRMS and structured RPO partnerships to scale recruitment and workforce administration efficiently across a multi-plant organisation.
- Financial Discipline: Sustained profitability improvement and a 1:1 bonus share issuance for FY 2024-25, reinforcing investor and employee confidence in the company's trajectory.

1.11 REGULATORY AND COMPLIANCE LANDSCAPE

Large manufacturing employers in India, including Ashok Leyland, operate within a dense regulatory framework governing employer-employee relations. Historically, this framework has been anchored in statutes such as the Industrial Disputes Act, 1947, the Factories Act, 1948, and the Trade Unions Act, 1926, each of which shapes how grievances, disputes, working conditions and union recognition are handled. In recent years, the Government of India has moved to consolidate these and related statutes into four comprehensive Labour Codes — covering wages, industrial relations, social security, and occupational safety, health and working conditions — with implementation being rolled out progressively across states.

For HR and Industrial Relations teams, this evolving regulatory landscape requires continuous monitoring and periodic updating of internal policies, documentation templates and escalation procedures. The Industrial Relations reference handbook that this internship contributed to preparing is itself a direct response to this need — providing employees and HR professionals with an accessible, current reference point for understanding their rights, obligations and the organisation's internal processes, rather than relying solely on scattered statutory text or informal knowledge.

Compliance in this context is not merely a legal obligation but a foundation for trust: consistent, transparent application of policy across a large, multi-plant workforce is what allows an organisation of Ashok Leyland's scale to maintain the kind of stable industrial relations that supports uninterrupted manufacturing operations.

1.12 EMPLOYER BRANDING AND TALENT ATTRACTION IN THE AUTOMOTIVE SECTOR

As competition for both engineering and HR talent intensifies across the automotive sector, employer branding has become an increasingly important consideration for large manufacturers such as Ashok Leyland. A strong employer brand not only supports recruitment efforts conducted through RPO partners but also plays a role in retention, as employees are more likely to remain engaged with organisations whose external reputation aligns with their internal experience.

Ashok Leyland's participation in industry platforms such as the EFSI Conference, its long-standing driver-training initiatives, and its visible investment in modernising HR technology all contribute to an employer brand that balances heritage and engineering credibility with a forward-looking, technology-enabled workplace culture. The intern's involvement in designing communication materials for the EFSI Conference offered a direct, practical window into how such employer-branding activities are planned and executed at the ground level.

1.13 SUSTAINABILITY, CSR AND WORKFORCE WELL-BEING

Alongside its business and product strategy, Ashok Leyland maintains a range of sustainability and corporate social responsibility (CSR) initiatives that intersect with its HR function, particularly in the areas of driver welfare and community skill-building. The company's long-running driver-training programme, which has trained over 800,000 drivers since inception, reflects a broader commitment to road safety and livelihood support that extends beyond the company's direct employee base.

Within the HR function itself, workforce well-being initiatives — including structured leave policies, safety training and grievance-redressal mechanisms observed during the internship — form part of a wider effort to ensure that operational growth does not come at the expense of employee welfare. For an HR intern, this reinforced the understanding that sustainable business performance in a manufacturing organisation is closely tied to the health, safety and engagement of its workforce, and that CSR and core HR practice are often more closely linked than they may first appear.

CHAPTER 2

JOB / TASK DESCRIPTION

2.1 OBJECTIVES OF THE INTERNSHIP

The primary objective of this internship was to bridge the gap between classroom learning in Human Resource Management, Organisational Behaviour and Industrial Relations, and the practical functioning of the HR and IR department of a large, unionised manufacturing organisation. Conducted at Ashok Leyland Limited over an eight-week period in 2025, the internship was structured to provide exposure to organisational induction, HR technology, HR analytics and reporting, Industrial Relations documentation, internal communication and event coordination, Learning & Development systems, and contemporary HR themes such as Artificial Intelligence in leadership.

Key Objectives

- Understanding Ashok Leyland's organisational structure and the fundamentals of Industrial Relations in a manufacturing environment.
- Gaining hands-on exposure to HR technology platforms, including the Recruitment Process Outsourcing (RPO) model and the Darwinbox HRMS.
- Developing HR analytics and reporting skills through preparation of the IR MIS report and an Employee Relations dashboard.
- Contributing to Industrial Relations knowledge management through a reference handbook for fresh employees and HR professionals.
- Building HR communication and event-coordination capability through the EFSI Conference flyer and agenda.
- Exploring Learning & Development systems and understanding automated training dashboards.
- Strengthening research, synthesis and presentation skills through structured presentations on AI in leadership and on automobile manufacturing trends.

2.2 METHODOLOGY AND APPROACH

The internship was structured as a task-based, week-wise program, with each week focusing on a distinct functional area of HR and Industrial Relations and culminating in a tangible deliverable. Work was carried out under the guidance of the HR and Industrial Relations team at Ashok Leyland, combining observation in the early weeks with increasing hands-on participation and independent contribution as the internship progressed.

2.3 INITIAL ONBOARDING AND ORGANISATIONAL INDUCTION

The internship began with a structured induction programme designed to familiarise the intern with Ashok Leyland's organisational structure, its position as the flagship company of the Hinduja Group, and the core functions of the HR and Industrial Relations department.

- Introduction to the company's history, products and manufacturing footprint.
- Overview of the HR department's structure, reporting lines and coordination with plant-level Industrial Relations teams.

- Orientation on workplace policies, code of conduct and the importance of confidentiality in handling employee data.
- Guided walkthroughs of how Industrial Relations activities are documented and escalated within the organisation.

2.4 WEEK-WISE WORK PLAN AND SCOPE

2.4.1 Week 1 — Organisation Induction and Industrial Relations

Area of Observation: Organisation overview, HR and Industrial Relations fundamentals

Work Performed: Attended the induction programme covering Ashok Leyland's history, structure and manufacturing operations. Assisted with routine Industrial Relations activities and documentation, including filing and updating IR records, and observed how the IR team engages with employee representatives on the shop floor.

- Studied the organisation chart of the HR and IR department and understood reporting lines between plant-level IR officers and the corporate HR team.
- Sat in on introductory briefings covering the company's code of conduct, data confidentiality expectations and workplace safety norms.
- Observed a routine IR case-file review, gaining a first-hand sense of how documentation supports fair and consistent resolution of workplace issues.

Personal Observation / Learning: Learned the fundamentals of Industrial Relations and the critical importance of maintaining a healthy, trust-based relationship between employer and employees in a large manufacturing setup. Understood how IR activity underpins production continuity and compliance.

2.4.2 Week 2 — Recruitment and HR Technology

Area of Observation: Recruitment Process and HRMS

Work Performed: Observed Ashok Leyland's Recruitment Process Outsourcing (RPO) model, including how external recruitment partners are briefed, how candidate pipelines are managed and how quality and turnaround-time metrics are tracked. Gained hands-on exposure to the Darwinbox HRMS platform, including modules for employee records, onboarding workflows and self-service features.

- Reviewed sample job requisitions and understood how role profiles are translated into sourcing briefs for RPO partners.
- Navigated the Darwinbox employee-record module to understand how master data (designation, grade, plant location) is structured and maintained.
- Observed how onboarding checklists are triggered automatically within Darwinbox once an offer is accepted, reducing manual coordination between HR and IT/Admin teams.

Personal Observation / Learning: Understood the end-to-end recruitment lifecycle, from requisition to onboarding, and how HR technology platforms such as Darwinbox streamline HR operations, reduce manual effort and improve data accuracy across a large, multi-plant workforce.

2.4.3 Week 3 — HR Analytics and MIS

Area of Observation: HR Reporting and Employee Relations Analytics

Work Performed: Prepared the monthly Industrial Relations Management Information System (IR MIS) report, consolidating data on attendance, grievances, disciplinary matters and union engagement across plants. Contributed to the development of a data-driven Employee Relations dashboard intended to give HR leadership real-time visibility into workforce sentiment and IR trends.

- Collected and cleaned raw attendance and grievance data from multiple plant-level sources before consolidation.
- Built summary pivot tables and visual charts in Excel to highlight month-on-month trends in IR case volumes.
- Discussed dashboard requirements with the HR analytics lead to ensure the output matched leadership's reporting expectations.

Personal Observation / Learning: Learned the importance of HR analytics, reporting accuracy and data-driven decision-making in Industrial Relations. Understood how a well-designed MIS report and dashboard can help leadership identify emerging IR issues before they escalate.

2.4.4 Week 4 — Industrial Relations Documentation

Area of Observation: Knowledge Management in Industrial Relations

Work Performed: Contributed to preparing an Industrial Relations reference handbook designed for fresh employees and HR professionals, consolidating key policies, escalation procedures, statutory obligations and frequently asked questions into a single, accessible document.

- Reviewed existing policy documents and past IR case notes to identify commonly asked questions for inclusion in the handbook.
- Drafted sections explaining grievance escalation procedures and the roles of various stakeholders in the IR process.
- Incorporated review feedback from senior HR staff to simplify language and improve readability for first-time users.

Personal Observation / Learning: Understood the value of structured documentation and knowledge-sharing in HR, particularly in a compliance-heavy function like Industrial Relations, where consistency and accessibility of information reduce risk and improve onboarding speed for new HR staff.

2.4.5 Week 5 — HR Communication and Event Coordination

Area of Observation: Corporate Communication and HR Events

Work Performed: Designed the flyer and agenda for the EFSI (Employers' Federation of Southern India) Conference, coordinating with internal stakeholders to finalise content, sequencing of sessions and branding elements, and supporting internal communication ahead of the event.

- Drafted multiple design concepts for the conference flyer and incorporated feedback from the corporate communications team.
- Structured the event agenda in consultation with session owners to ensure logical sequencing and appropriate time allocation.
- Coordinated logistics-related communication, including invitee lists and confirmation follow-ups, ahead of the conference.

Personal Observation / Learning: Gained practical exposure to HR communication, branding and event coordination, and understood how well-organised internal events strengthen the organisation's engagement with external industry bodies and reinforce its employer brand.

2.4.6 Week 6 — Learning and Development

Area of Observation: Learning & Development Systems

Work Performed: Explored the automated Learning & Development dashboard used to track training nominations, completions and effectiveness scores across the organisation, and reviewed how training needs are identified and mapped to competency frameworks.

- Reviewed how training calendars are built around identified skill gaps and statutory/mandatory training requirements.
- Examined dashboard views summarising nomination-to-completion ratios and post-training feedback scores by department.
- Discussed with the L&D team how training effectiveness data feeds back into future programme design.

Personal Observation / Learning: Learned how technology supports employee learning, skill development and performance improvement, and understood the role of structured L&D tracking in building a future-ready workforce for a manufacturing organisation navigating electrification and digitalisation.

2.4.7 Week 7 — HR Presentation on AI in Leadership

Area of Observation: Artificial Intelligence Applications in Human Resource Management

Work Performed: Conducted secondary research and delivered a presentation on 'AI in Leadership and Decision Making' to the HR team, covering how AI tools are being used for talent analytics, sentiment analysis and decision support in modern HR functions.

- Researched case examples of AI-enabled talent analytics, workforce sentiment analysis and predictive attrition modelling.
- Structured the presentation to connect global AI-in-HR trends with practical implications for Ashok Leyland's own HR technology roadmap.
- Incorporated Q&A feedback from the HR team to refine the framing of AI's role as a decision-support tool rather than a replacement for human judgement.

Personal Observation / Learning: Understood the growing impact of AI on leadership, talent management and strategic HR decision-making, and gained confidence in synthesising external research into a structured, presentation-ready format for an internal professional audience.

2.4.8 Week 8 — Industry Trends and Final Learning

Area of Observation: Future of Industrial and Automobile Manufacturing

Work Performed: Prepared and delivered a presentation on 'Current and Future Trends in Industrial and Automobile Manufacturing', focusing on electrification, automation, digital transformation and workforce evolution, and consolidated key learnings from the internship for a closing discussion with the HR team.

- Researched industry trends including electrification, alternative fuels, automation on the shop floor and connected-vehicle technology.
- Linked these industry trends to their implications for future workforce skilling and HR strategy at Ashok Leyland.
- Presented a closing summary of internship learnings and received structured feedback from the HR and IR team on overall performance.

Personal Observation / Learning: Gained insights into emerging industry trends and their influence on HR, Industrial Relations and future workforce planning, and reflected on how the skills gained through the internship would apply to a future career in Human Resources.

2.5 TIMELINE OF ACTIVITIES

Week	Duration	Key Activities
Week 1	Days 1–5	Induction; organisational overview; assisted with routine Industrial

		Relations documentation.
Week 2	Days 6–10	Observed RPO recruitment model; hands-on exposure to Darwinbox HRMS.
Week 3	Days 11–15	Prepared IR MIS report; contributed to Employee Relations dashboard.
Week 4	Days 16–20	Contributed to Industrial Relations reference handbook for fresh employees and HR professionals.
Week 5	Days 21–25	Designed EFSI Conference flyer and agenda; supported internal HR communication.
Week 6	Days 26–30	Explored automated Learning & Development dashboard and training tracking process.
Week 7	Days 31–35	Researched and delivered presentation on 'AI in Leadership and Decision Making'.
Week 8	Days 36–40	Delivered presentation on 'Current and Future Trends in Industrial and Automobile Manufacturing'; consolidated learnings.

2.6 TOOLS AND SYSTEMS USED

2.6.1 Darwinbox HRMS

Darwinbox served as the central Human Resource Management System used for employee records, onboarding workflows and self-service functions. Working with Darwinbox provided an understanding of how a modern, cloud-based HRMS consolidates the employee lifecycle — from recruitment through onboarding, records management and reporting — into a single integrated platform.

2.6.2 Recruitment Process Outsourcing (RPO) Model

Exposure to the RPO model helped in understanding how Ashok Leyland partners with external recruitment agencies to manage high-volume hiring, while retaining oversight of quality, turnaround time and candidate experience through defined service-level agreements and periodic reviews.

2.6.3 Microsoft Excel

Excel was essential for consolidating data for the IR MIS report and the Employee Relations dashboard, using pivot tables, conditional formatting and summary charts to convert raw workforce and IR data into management-ready insights.

2.6.4 Microsoft PowerPoint and Word

PowerPoint was used to design the EFSI Conference flyer and agenda and to build the two research presentations delivered during the internship, while Word was used to draft and format the Industrial Relations reference handbook and other internal documentation, ensuring clarity and professional presentation.

2.6.5 Learning & Development (L&D) Dashboard

The automated L&D dashboard provided visibility into training nominations, completions and feedback scores, illustrating how technology supports structured, trackable employee development at scale.

2.9.1 KEY DELIVERABLES SUMMARY

Deliverable	Week	Nature of Contribution
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Team role-mapping notes	1	Observational documentation of HR/IR team structure
Darwinbox & RPO orientation notes	2	Guided exploration and documentation of platform features
IR MIS Report	3	Direct data consolidation and report preparation
Employee Relations Dashboard	3	Collaborative dashboard design contribution
IR Reference Handbook (sections)	4	Drafting and refinement of handbook content
EFSI Conference Flyer & Agenda	5	Design and coordination
L&D Dashboard Review Notes	6	Observational analysis and documentation
Presentation: AI in Leadership	7	Independent research and delivery
Presentation: Manufacturing Trends	8	Independent research and delivery

2.10 DOCUMENTATION STANDARDS FOLLOWED

Given the compliance-sensitive nature of Industrial Relations work, particular attention was paid throughout the internship to following the organisation's documentation standards. This included maintaining version control on the IR reference handbook drafts, using consistent naming conventions for MIS report files, and ensuring that any employee-identifiable data used in reports and dashboards was handled strictly in accordance with the company's data confidentiality policy. These practices reinforced classroom learning on data governance and research ethics, applied here in a live organisational setting.

- All draft documents were saved with clear version labels and dates to maintain an auditable trail of revisions.
- Sensitive employee data used in MIS reports was aggregated or anonymised wherever the analysis did not require individual-level detail.
- Feedback and review comments from the HR team were incorporated in tracked or clearly marked revisions before finalisation.

2.7 APPLICATION OF ACADEMIC KNOWLEDGE

One of the most valuable aspects of the internship was the opportunity to directly apply concepts from the MBA (Human Resources) curriculum to real workplace situations at Ashok Leyland.

2.7.1 Industrial Relations

- Applied classroom concepts of grievance handling, union engagement and dispute resolution while assisting with IR documentation and the IR MIS report.
- Understood how statutory frameworks such as the Industrial Disputes Act and the Factories Act translate into day-to-day IR practice on the shop floor.

2.7.2 Human Resource Information Systems

- Related classroom learning on HRIS and e-HR to practical use of the Darwinbox platform for employee data management and workflow automation.
- Understood how RPO models operationalise recruitment theory into a scalable, outsourced hiring process.

2.7.3 HR Analytics

- Applied data analysis and dashboard-design concepts learned in academic coursework to build the Employee Relations dashboard and IR MIS report.
- Understood how descriptive analytics support proactive Industrial Relations management rather than purely reactive problem-solving.

2.7.4 Training and Development

- Connected academic frameworks on training needs analysis and Kirkpatrick's evaluation model to the practical tracking of training interventions on the L&D dashboard.

2.7.5 Organisational Behaviour and Communication

- Applied principles of organisational communication and stakeholder management while designing the EFSI Conference flyer and agenda and while researching and delivering the two HR presentations.

2.8 CHALLENGES FACED DURING THE INTERNSHIP

Like any first exposure to a corporate HR and Industrial Relations environment, the internship presented a number of challenges that required guided problem-solving and gradual skill-building.

- **Unfamiliar Terminology:** Industrial Relations and labour-law terminology encountered in Week 1 was initially unfamiliar and required focused reading and mentorship to grasp accurately.
- **Data Consolidation Complexity:** Consolidating attendance and grievance data from multiple plant-level sources for the IR MIS report required careful cross-checking to avoid inconsistencies.
- **Balancing Multiple Deliverables:** Coordinating the EFSI Conference materials alongside ongoing MIS reporting responsibilities in Week 5 required disciplined time management.
- **Presenting to a Senior Audience:** Delivering research-based presentations to experienced HR professionals in Weeks 7 and 8 required building confidence in structuring and defending recommendations.

2.9 SUPPORT AND GUIDANCE RECEIVED

Throughout the internship, the HR and Industrial Relations team at Ashok Leyland provided consistent mentorship, constructive feedback and the operational context required to complete each deliverable with confidence. Regular check-ins helped clarify expectations for each week's task, while structured feedback after the Week 7 presentation directly improved the quality and delivery of the Week 8 presentation. This mentorship culture reinforced the intern's understanding of how large organisations balance guidance with increasing autonomy as new team members demonstrate capability.

2.12 REFLECTIONS ON WORKING IN A UNIONISED MANUFACTURING ENVIRONMENT

Working within the HR and Industrial Relations function of a large, unionised manufacturing organisation offered a perspective quite different from the more transactional, individual-employee-focused HR practices often emphasised in classroom case studies drawn from service-sector or start-up contexts. In a plant environment, decisions around scheduling, grievance resolution or policy communication must account for collective as well as individual interests, and IR professionals must

navigate a more formal, procedurally structured set of relationships with employee representative bodies.

This experience underscored the importance of consistency and procedural fairness in every piece of documentation and communication — a theme that recurred across nearly every task undertaken during the internship, from the IR MIS report to the reference handbook. It also highlighted how, in such environments, small lapses in documentation or communication can have outsized consequences for trust and industrial harmony, reinforcing the value of the meticulous, detail-oriented approach encouraged by the HR team throughout the internship.

2.13 OBSERVATIONS ON CROSS-PLANT COORDINATION

A recurring theme across several weeks of the internship — particularly during preparation of the IR MIS report and the reference handbook — was the coordination required between the corporate HR team and plant-level IR contacts. Data for the MIS report had to be sourced consistently from multiple plants, each with slightly different local reporting habits, requiring careful follow-up and standardisation before consolidation. Similarly, content for the reference handbook needed to reflect practices that would be broadly applicable across plants, rather than reflecting only the corporate office context.

This cross-plant coordination requirement offered a practical illustration of a challenge common to HR functions in any multi-location manufacturing organisation: balancing the need for centralised consistency with respect for legitimate local variation in day-to-day practice. Navigating this balance, even in a limited internship capacity, was a valuable exercise in stakeholder management and diplomatic communication.

CHAPTER 3

ANALYSIS OF JOB PERFORMANCE

3.1 QUALITY OF WORK

Throughout the internship, a consistent focus was maintained on accuracy, clarity and professionalism across all deliverables. The intern was entrusted with responsibilities ranging from IR documentation and MIS reporting to HRMS exposure, handbook preparation, event communication and formal presentations, each of which demanded a different combination of analytical and interpersonal skill. The quality of work improved progressively across the eight weeks, moving from close supervision during induction to independent contribution by the later weeks.

- The IR MIS report and Employee Relations dashboard were prepared with attention to data accuracy and clear, management-ready formatting.
- The Industrial Relations reference handbook was structured logically, with content reviewed and refined based on feedback from the HR team.
- The EFSI Conference flyer and agenda were designed to be visually clear and aligned with the organisation's communication standards.
- Both research presentations were well-structured, appropriately referenced and delivered with clarity to a professional HR audience.

3.2 TIMELINESS AND TASK OWNERSHIP

As the internship progressed, the intern demonstrated increasing ownership of assigned tasks, completing deliverables such as the IR MIS report, the reference handbook sections and the conference materials within the agreed timelines. Coordination for inputs from various stakeholders within the HR team was handled proactively, and any dependencies or delays were communicated promptly to the reporting manager.

3.3 ADAPTABILITY AND LEARNING CURVE

Despite having no prior exposure to Darwinbox HRMS, RPO recruitment models or IR MIS reporting formats, the intern adapted quickly within the first two weeks of the internship. Confidence in using Excel-based reporting tools, understanding IR terminology and navigating the HRMS platform improved steadily through repeated practice and guidance from the HR team.

- Learned to navigate the Darwinbox HRMS platform and understand its core modules within the first two weeks.
- Became proficient in structuring MIS reports and dashboards using Excel pivot tables and conditional formatting.
- Adapted quickly to new formats for IR documentation and handbook preparation, applying feedback from senior HR staff.
- Showed initiative in researching independently for the AI-in-leadership and industry-trends presentations.

3.4 COMMUNICATION AND COLLABORATION

Professional communication and collaboration were central to the internship experience at Ashok Leyland, given the cross-functional nature of HR and Industrial Relations work.

- Maintained clear, respectful communication with the HR and IR team while gathering inputs for the MIS report and reference handbook.
- Coordinated with internal stakeholders to finalise content and design for the EFSI Conference flyer and agenda, balancing multiple inputs under time pressure.
- Presented reconciled data and structured reports (IR MIS, dashboard) in formats that were easy for supervisors to review and act upon.
- Sought clarification proactively when encountering unfamiliar IR terminology or HRMS workflows, and incorporated feedback constructively into subsequent tasks.

3.5 STRENGTHS DEMONSTRATED

- Attention to Detail: Maintained accuracy in IR MIS data consolidation and handbook content.
- Ownership: Took responsibility for assigned deliverables and followed up on pending inputs without requiring reminders.
- Quick Learning: Adapted to Darwinbox HRMS, RPO processes and IR reporting formats with minimal training.
- Communication: Coordinated effectively across HR, IR and event-related stakeholders.
- Presentation Skills: Delivered two structured, well-researched presentations to a professional audience.

3.6 AREAS FOR IMPROVEMENT

- Familiarity with IR Terminology: Initial unfamiliarity with certain IR and labour-law terms was overcome through guided reading and mentorship.
- Dashboard Design Skills: Confidence in advanced Excel dashboard techniques improved gradually with practice and feedback.
- Public Presentation Confidence: Comfort in presenting to senior HR professionals improved after the first presentation, informing a more confident delivery in Week 8.
- Document Structuring: Learned to organise the reference handbook more intuitively for end users after incorporating review feedback.

3.7 SELF-ASSESSMENT OF SKILLS

At the start and end of the internship, the intern undertook a brief self-assessment across key HR-relevant skill areas on a five-point scale (1 = Beginner, 5 = Confident and Independent). The comparison below illustrates the progression observed over the eight weeks.

Skill Area	Start of Internship	End of Internship
Understanding of Industrial Relations concepts	2	4
HRMS (Darwinbox) navigation	1	4
Excel-based MIS/dashboard reporting	2	4
Business/HR documentation writing	3	4
Event and communication coordination	2	4
Formal presentation and public speaking	2	4

The consistent improvement across all six skill areas reflects the structured, progressively challenging nature of the internship design, and the mentorship provided by the HR and IR team at Ashok Leyland.

3.7.1 Performance Progression Across the Internship

Reviewing performance chronologically across the eight weeks reveals a clear arc: Weeks 1–2 were characterised by observation, guided learning and heavy reliance on supervisory support, particularly while becoming familiar with IR terminology and the Darwinbox HRMS. By Weeks 3–4, the intern was contributing directly to analytical and documentation deliverables (the IR MIS report and reference handbook) with moderate supervision. Weeks 5–6 introduced cross-functional coordination demands (event communication, L&D exposure), requiring greater initiative and stakeholder management. By Weeks 7–8, the intern was operating with a high degree of independence, conducting original research and delivering formal presentations to the HR team with minimal guidance.

This trajectory mirrors the intended design of the internship programme and reflects a realistic model of how new HR professionals typically progress from guided execution to independent contribution within their first few months in a role.

3.7.2 EVALUATION CRITERIA AND OUTCOMES

Performance during the internship was informally evaluated by the HR team against a set of criteria commonly used for early-career HR professionals. The table below summarises these criteria and the corresponding outcomes observed.

Evaluation Criterion	Observed Outcome
Accuracy of data and documentation	Consistently high; minor early errors in Week 1–2 were corrected with guidance
Timeliness of deliverables	All deliverables completed within agreed timelines
Initiative and proactivity	Increased steadily; notably strong from Week 5 onward
Communication and stakeholder coordination	Effective; well received in EFSI Conference coordination and presentations
Adaptability to new tools/processes	Strong; new platforms (Darwinbox, dashboards) learned quickly

3.8 FEEDBACK FROM THE REPORTING TEAM

Periodic feedback from the HR and Industrial Relations team highlighted the intern's steady improvement in accuracy, initiative and professional communication over the course of the internship. Early feedback focused on building familiarity with IR terminology and HRMS navigation, while feedback in the later weeks recognised the intern's growing independence in preparing MIS reports, structuring the reference handbook, and confidently presenting research findings to the team. This progression from guided execution to independent contribution was consistently noted as a positive indicator of readiness for a professional HR role.

3.9 COMPARISON WITH INDUSTRY BEST PRACTICES

Benchmarking the tasks undertaken during this internship against commonly cited industry best practices in HR and Industrial Relations reveals strong alignment. The use of a centralised HRMS (Darwinbox) for employee data mirrors leading practice among large Indian and global manufacturers, who increasingly consolidate HR data onto single platforms to improve consistency and reduce

administrative overhead. Similarly, the preparation of a structured, dashboard-supported IR MIS report reflects a broader industry shift toward proactive, data-informed Industrial Relations management, rather than a purely reactive, case-by-case approach.

The creation of a reference handbook for fresh employees and HR professionals also reflects recognised best practice in knowledge management — reducing dependency on tacit, individually held knowledge and instead building institutional memory that persists even as team members change. Overall, the tasks assigned during this internship were not merely administrative exercises but were closely aligned with the kinds of practices that distinguish well-run HR and IR functions in large manufacturing organisations.

3.10 PEER AND TEAM INTERACTION

Beyond formal reporting relationships, the internship also involved regular interaction with peers across the HR, IR, communications and L&D teams. These interactions — whether clarifying data definitions for the MIS report, discussing content for the reference handbook, or coordinating logistics for the EFSI Conference — helped the intern build a working understanding of how cross-functional HR teams collaborate on shared organisational priorities. Team members were generally supportive and willing to explain unfamiliar concepts, which significantly eased the early learning curve described in Section 3.3.

This collaborative environment also modelled a professional norm that the intern sought to emulate throughout the internship: raising questions early, documenting agreed decisions clearly, and following up proactively rather than waiting to be reminded — practices that were positively acknowledged in periodic feedback from the reporting team.

CHAPTER 4

LEARNING OUTCOMES

4.1 FUNCTIONAL KNOWLEDGE ACQUIRED

- Industrial Relations Fundamentals: Gained a working understanding of grievance handling, union engagement, IR documentation and the statutory context governing employer-employee relations in a manufacturing organisation.
- HRMS Proficiency: Developed familiarity with the Darwinbox platform, including employee records management, onboarding workflows and self-service modules.
- Recruitment Process Outsourcing: Understood how RPO partnerships are structured, monitored and evaluated for quality and turnaround time.
- HR Analytics and MIS Reporting: Learned to consolidate and present IR and workforce data through structured MIS reports and dashboards.
- Learning & Development Tracking: Understood how automated L&D dashboards support structured, measurable employee development.

4.2 PRACTICAL EXPOSURE TO HR BUSINESS PROCESSES

The internship offered insight into how a large manufacturing organisation's HR function is structured and how its various sub-functions interconnect.

- Understanding Workflow Dependencies: Learned how recruitment, HRMS data, IR reporting and L&D tracking depend on accurate, timely data flow between teams.
- Coordination Across Teams: Experienced how HR, IR, and corporate communication functions coordinate for organisation-wide initiatives such as the EFSI Conference.
- Documentation Discipline: Understood the procedural discipline required to prepare compliance-relevant documents such as the IR reference handbook.

4.3 IMPROVEMENT IN ANALYTICAL AND SYSTEMS THINKING

- Cross-Functional Validation: Developed the habit of validating data across HRMS records and IR reports before finalising the MIS dashboard.
- Pattern Recognition: Became more attentive to recurring themes in IR data that could signal emerging employee-relations issues.
- Decision-Support Thinking: Understood how accurate HR analytics feed into leadership decisions on workforce planning and IR strategy.

4.4 SOFT SKILLS AND PROFESSIONAL TRAITS STRENGTHENED

- Time Management: Learned to balance recurring responsibilities (MIS reporting) with project-based deliverables (handbook, conference materials, presentations) within tight deadlines.
- Communication Skills: Strengthened both written communication (handbook, reports) and verbal presentation skills (two formal presentations to the HR team).
- Adaptability: Adjusted quickly to new tools, formats and functional areas across the eight-week rotation through HR sub-functions.

- Accountability and Professionalism: Took ownership of assigned tasks, honoured deadlines and incorporated feedback constructively.

4.5 ALIGNMENT WITH ACADEMIC LEARNING

Academic Subject	Internship Application
Industrial Relations & Labour Laws	IR documentation, IR MIS reporting, and the Industrial Relations reference handbook
Human Resource Information Systems	Hands-on exposure to the Darwinbox HRMS and RPO recruitment model
HR Analytics	Preparation of the Employee Relations dashboard and MIS reports
Training and Development	Exploration of the automated Learning & Development dashboard
Organisational Behaviour & Communication	EFSI Conference flyer/agenda design and internal HR communication
Strategic HRM / Emerging Technologies	Research and presentation on AI in Leadership and Decision Making

4.6 OVERALL REALISATIONS

- Learned that Industrial Relations is as much about proactive communication and documentation as it is about statutory compliance.
- Realised the growing importance of HR technology and analytics in enabling timely, informed workforce decisions in large manufacturing organisations.
- Experienced how HR functions as a strategic partner to the business, balancing compliance, culture and capability-building simultaneously.

4.7 PROFESSIONAL INSIGHTS AND LEARNINGS

a. Professional Development

- Adapted to the expectations of a corporate HR environment where accuracy, discretion and initiative are highly valued.
- Improved professional communication through coordination with the HR and IR team and cross-functional stakeholders for the EFSI Conference.

b. Technical Proficiency

- Acquired practical exposure to Darwinbox HRMS, RPO recruitment processes and Excel-based HR analytics.
- Enhanced the ability to consolidate workforce data from multiple sources into clear, decision-ready reports.

c. Functional Understanding of HR and Industrial Relations

- Observed the HR and IR team's role as custodians of workplace compliance, harmony and employee experience.

- Understood the importance of timely IR reporting and structured documentation in sustaining industrial peace.

d. Process Discipline and Accountability

- Recognised the importance of maintaining organised, review-ready documentation for IR and HR audit purposes.
- Strengthened accountability through consistent follow-ups and timely updates to the reporting manager.

e. Adaptability and Continuous Learning

- Adjusted quickly to new HR systems, reporting formats and functional rotations across the eight weeks.
- Embraced a mindset of continuous learning, particularly while researching AI applications in HR and industry trends in automobile manufacturing.

4.8 SKILLS MATRIX DEVELOPED DURING THE INTERNSHIP

Skill Category	Specific Skills Developed
Technical / Systems	Darwinbox HRMS navigation, Excel-based MIS reporting, dashboard design
Functional HR Knowledge	Industrial Relations documentation, RPO recruitment process, L&D tracking
Communication	Business writing (handbook, reports), event communication, formal presentation delivery
Analytical	Data consolidation, trend identification, decision-support reporting
Behavioural	Ownership, adaptability, professionalism, cross-functional collaboration

4.9 RELEVANCE TO FUTURE CAREER IN HUMAN RESOURCES

The breadth of exposure gained during this internship — spanning Industrial Relations, HR technology, analytics, documentation, communication and Learning & Development — closely mirrors the generalist HR roles that MBA graduates typically enter early in their careers. The experience of working across sub-functions in a single, well-structured rotation gave the intern a realistic preview of how HR generalists must move fluidly between compliance-oriented tasks (IR documentation), technology-oriented tasks (HRMS), analytical tasks (MIS reporting) and people-oriented tasks (communication and events).

This holistic exposure is expected to be particularly valuable for a career in Human Resources within manufacturing or other large, compliance-intensive industries, where Industrial Relations fluency, digital HR competence and strong communication skills are all essential for long-term success.

4.10 BROADER REFLECTIONS ON HR AS A CAREER PATH

Beyond the specific technical and functional learnings, the internship prompted broader reflection on what a career in Human Resources — particularly within Industrial Relations — genuinely demands. It became evident that successful HR and IR professionals combine three distinct capabilities: procedural rigour (to ensure compliance and consistency), interpersonal sensitivity (to manage relationships across

hierarchical and sometimes adversarial contexts), and increasingly, analytical fluency (to translate workforce data into decisions that leadership can act upon).

The internship also highlighted that Industrial Relations, often perceived by students as a narrow, compliance-only specialisation, is in practice deeply intertwined with organisational strategy — influencing everything from production continuity to employer brand and even investor confidence, given how closely workforce stability is tied to operational performance in a manufacturing-heavy business like Ashok Leyland. This realisation has meaningfully shaped the intern's own thinking about which HR sub-functions to pursue further in a future career.

4.11 INDUSTRY CONTEXT REFLECTION

Reflecting on the internship against the backdrop of Ashok Leyland's broader industry position, it became clear that the HR and Industrial Relations function does not operate in isolation from business strategy. The company's stated ambition to expand into export markets, accelerate electrification and deepen technology partnerships all carry direct implications for the workforce — from the need for new technical skills to the importance of maintaining industrial harmony while operational processes evolve. The IR MIS report and Employee Relations dashboard prepared during the internship, though modest in scope, exemplify the kind of data-driven visibility that large manufacturing organisations increasingly need to manage this transition smoothly.

This reinforced a broader realisation: HR and IR professionals in a company like Ashok Leyland are not merely administrators of policy, but active contributors to the organisation's ability to execute its strategic priorities — whether that means supporting a smooth ramp-up of a new manufacturing line, managing the workforce implications of new technology adoption, or ensuring that industrial relations remain stable through periods of significant organisational change.

4.12 LIMITATIONS OF THE INTERNSHIP EXPERIENCE

While the internship provided broad and valuable exposure, it is important to acknowledge certain limitations. As an eight-week internship, the depth of involvement in any single sub-function (recruitment, IR, analytics, L&D) was necessarily limited compared to what a permanent team member would experience over months or years. Exposure to live, high-stakes Industrial Relations situations — such as active dispute resolution or union negotiations — was largely observational rather than participative, given the sensitivity and confidentiality such matters require.

Additionally, as a short-term intern, access to certain systems and historical data was appropriately restricted in line with the organisation's data governance policies, which meant some analyses (such as the IR MIS report) were necessarily based on a limited data window rather than a full historical trend. These limitations do not diminish the value of the learning experience, but they are noted here in the interest of providing an honest and complete account of the internship's scope.

4.13 COMPARISON BETWEEN EXPECTATIONS AND REALITY

Prior to commencing the internship, expectations were shaped largely by classroom coverage of HR functions, which often presents recruitment, IR, analytics and L&D as discrete, cleanly separated topics. In practice, the internship revealed how closely interconnected these functions are on a day-to-day basis: the same underlying employee data feeds both the HRMS and the IR MIS report; communication skills developed while drafting the reference handbook were directly reused while designing the EFSI Conference materials; and the research discipline built while preparing the AI-in-leadership presentation directly supported the quality of the Week 8 industry-trends presentation.

This interconnectedness was, in many ways, the most significant learning of the internship — reinforcing that effective HR professionals must think and operate across functional boundaries rather than treating each HR sub-discipline as an isolated silo.

4.14 RECOMMENDATIONS FOR CURRICULUM ALIGNMENT

Reflecting on the gap between classroom preparation and the practical demands of this internship, a few observations emerge that may be useful for academic programme design. Greater emphasis on practical, tool-based exposure — such as hands-on exercises with HRMS platforms, Excel-based MIS reporting and dashboard design — would help future students transition more quickly into similar internship roles. Likewise, case-based coverage of Industrial Relations that goes beyond statutory theory to include realistic documentation exercises (such as drafting a grievance-handling note or an MIS summary) would better prepare students for the analytical and writing demands actually encountered in the workplace.

Equally, incorporating structured presentation and business-communication practice into the curriculum — mirroring the Week 7 and Week 8 presentations undertaken during this internship — would help build the confidence required to present research-based recommendations to experienced professional audiences.

CHAPTER 5

SUMMARY AND CONCLUSION

5.1 SUMMARY OF INTERNSHIP EXPERIENCE

The internship at Ashok Leyland Limited offered an immersive experience in the Human Resources and Industrial Relations function of a large, flagship manufacturing organisation of the Hinduja Group. Over eight weeks, the intern was exposed to organisational induction, recruitment technology, HR analytics and MIS reporting, Industrial Relations documentation, internal communication and event coordination, Learning & Development systems, and contemporary HR research and presentation.

From understanding the fundamentals of Industrial Relations in Week 1 to independently researching and presenting on AI in Leadership and on industry trends by Week 8, the internship reflected a clear progression from observation to active contribution. The intern worked with real organisational data and systems, including the Darwinbox HRMS, IR MIS reports, the Employee Relations dashboard, the Industrial Relations reference handbook, and materials for the EFSI Conference.

5.2 KEY TAKEAWAYS

5.2.1 Process-Level Thinking

- Understood that HR and Industrial Relations function as interconnected processes, where data from recruitment, HRMS and IR reporting feed into organisation-wide decision-making.
- Observed how each function — recruitment, IR documentation, analytics, communication and L&D — must work in sequence to sustain a compliant, engaged workforce.

5.2.2 Decision-Making Awareness

- Recognised the criticality of accurate, timely IR data in supporting leadership decisions on employee relations and workforce planning.
- Understood how documentation gaps or delayed reporting in IR can escalate minor issues into larger disputes.

5.2.3 Workplace Discipline

- Developed habits of structured reporting, proactive follow-up and organised documentation essential to HR and IR functions.
- Maintained punctuality and professionalism in coordinating across teams for time-bound deliverables such as the EFSI Conference materials.

5.2.4 Exposure to Industrial Relations in Practice

- Experienced how a large manufacturing organisation manages Industrial Relations across multiple plants and stakeholder groups.
- Understood the importance of accurate documentation and communication in maintaining industrial harmony and statutory compliance.

5.2.5 Digital and Analytical Readiness

- Worked across multiple HR systems and tools, understanding how digital platforms reduce manual effort and improve decision quality.

- Realised the value of HR analytics and dashboards in translating raw workforce data into actionable insight.

5.2.6 Collaboration and Cross-Functional Coordination

- Understood the importance of inter-departmental collaboration in HR, IR and internal communication initiatives.
- Built confidence in asking the right questions, incorporating feedback and contributing meaningfully within a professional HR team.

5.3 RECOMMENDATIONS FOR FUTURE INTERNS

- Invest time early in understanding organisational structure and terminology specific to Industrial Relations, as this foundation accelerates comprehension of all subsequent tasks.
- Proactively seek feedback after each deliverable rather than waiting for scheduled reviews, as iterative feedback significantly improves the quality of documentation and presentations.
- Maintain a running log of tools, terminology and processes encountered each week; this practice proved valuable in preparing this report and would benefit future interns similarly.
- Approach analytics tasks (such as MIS reporting) with a habit of cross-verifying data from multiple sources before finalising reports, to build a reputation for accuracy early on.

5.4 RECOMMENDATIONS TO THE ORGANISATION

- Consider providing a brief glossary of IR and HR-technology terminology to interns during induction, which would reduce the initial learning curve observed in Week 1 and Week 2.
- Formalise a short mid-internship review checkpoint (in addition to the final review) to allow interns to recalibrate priorities and address any skill gaps earlier in the programme.
- Continue to expand the automated Learning & Development and Employee Relations dashboards, as these tools were highly valued for the visibility they provide to both HR leadership and new team members.

5.5 PERSONAL REFLECTION

On a personal level, this internship was as much a lesson in professional maturity as it was in technical HR skill. Arriving with primarily theoretical exposure to Industrial Relations and HR systems, the eight weeks at Ashok Leyland offered a grounded, week-by-week education in how large organisations actually manage their people, their compliance obligations and their internal communication. The steady progression from shadowing team members in Week 1 to independently researching and presenting on industry trends in Week 8 was, in itself, a meaningful demonstration of how quickly practical capability can be built when structured exposure is paired with consistent mentorship.

The intern leaves this internship with not only a stronger technical foundation in HRMS, MIS reporting and IR documentation, but also a clearer sense of professional identity — an appreciation for the quieter, process-driven side of HR (documentation, compliance, analytics) alongside the more visible, people-facing side (communication, events, presentations). Both dimensions, the internship made clear, are equally essential to effective Human Resource Management in a modern manufacturing organisation.

5.6 CONCLUSION

The internship at Ashok Leyland Limited was a valuable milestone in both the academic and professional journey of the intern. It bridged the gap between theoretical understanding of Human

Resource Management, Organisational Behaviour and Industrial Relations, and their practical application within a large, unionised manufacturing organisation, enabling the development of a solid foundation in Industrial Relations documentation, HR technology, HR analytics, internal communication and Learning & Development.

Working with a professional and experienced HR and IR team gave the intern valuable insight into how a flagship organisation such as Ashok Leyland balances compliance, employee engagement and digital transformation in today's evolving manufacturing and mobility landscape. The guidance, exposure and structured feedback received throughout the internship not only refined the intern's technical and analytical skills but also strengthened confidence and clarity about pursuing a career in Human Resources and Industrial Relations.

In conclusion, this internship has equipped the intern with the skills, discipline and professional understanding required to transition successfully from an MBA Human Resources student to a workplace-ready HR professional, capable of contributing meaningfully to any HR or Industrial Relations team in the future.

APPENDIX A — GLOSSARY OF KEY TERMS

Term	Meaning
IR	Industrial Relations — the management of the relationship between employer and employees, including unions and employee representatives.
MIS	Management Information System — structured, periodic reporting used to support management decision-making.
HRMS	Human Resource Management System — a software platform used to manage employee data and HR processes.
RPO	Recruitment Process Outsourcing — engaging an external partner to manage all or part of the recruitment process.
L&D	Learning & Development — the organisational function responsible for employee training and capability-building.
EFSI	Employers' Federation of Southern India — an industry body representing employer interests in Southern India.
Grievance	A formal complaint raised by an employee regarding a workplace issue, typically handled through a defined escalation process.
Employee Relations Dashboard	A visual reporting tool summarising workforce and IR metrics for HR leadership.

APPENDIX B — WEEKLY TASK CHECKLIST

Week	Primary Deliverable	Status
1	Induction completion and IR documentation assistance	Completed
2	RPO and Darwinbox HRMS orientation	Completed
3	IR MIS report and Employee Relations dashboard	Completed
4	Industrial Relations reference handbook (contribution)	Completed
5	EFSI Conference flyer and agenda	Completed
6	L&D dashboard review	Completed
7	Presentation: AI in Leadership and Decision Making	Completed
8	Presentation: Trends in Industrial and Automobile Manufacturing	Completed

APPENDIX C — INDICATIVE STRUCTURE OF THE IR MIS REPORT

The Industrial Relations MIS report prepared during Week 3 of the internship was structured to give HR leadership a concise, plant-wise view of key Industrial Relations indicators. Its indicative structure is summarised below.

Section	Content Covered
Attendance Summary	Plant-wise attendance percentage, absenteeism trends and overtime hours for the reporting month
Grievance Tracker	Number of grievances raised, resolved and pending, categorised by type and plant
Disciplinary Matters	Summary of ongoing and closed disciplinary cases, with resolution timelines
Union Engagement Log	Record of formal and informal engagements with employee representative bodies
Key Observations	Narrative highlights and emerging themes flagged for leadership attention

APPENDIX D — EFSI CONFERENCE MATERIALS: CONTENT OUTLINE

The flyer and agenda designed for the EFSI Conference in Week 5 were structured around the following broad content blocks, developed in coordination with the corporate communications and HR teams.

- **Event Title and Theme:** A clear, prominent title communicating the conference's central theme and host organisation branding.
- **Date, Venue and Registration Details:** Practical logistical information presented prominently for easy reference.
- **Session Agenda:** A time-sequenced list of sessions, speakers and topics, structured to balance keynote sessions with panel discussions.
- **Speaker Highlights:** Brief introductions of key speakers to build credibility and audience interest ahead of the event.
- **Contact and Coordination Details:** Point-of-contact information for queries and confirmations.

APPENDIX E — WEEKLY REFLECTION JOURNAL EXCERPTS

As a personal practice, the intern maintained a brief weekly reflection journal throughout the internship. Illustrative excerpts, summarised by theme, are presented below.

Week	Reflection Theme
1	Realised how much of Industrial Relations depends on clear, consistent documentation rather than only interpersonal skill.
2	Appreciated how much manual effort HRMS platforms like Darwinbox eliminate from routine HR administration.
3	Learned that a good MIS report is as much about asking the right question of the data as it is about formatting it well.
4	Understood that writing for a broad, non-expert audience (the handbook) is a different skill from writing internal notes.
5	Discovered how much planning goes into what looks, from the outside, like a simple event flyer and agenda.
6	Recognised that training data, tracked consistently, can reveal real gaps in workforce capability before they become visible elsewhere.
7	Built confidence in defending a researched point of view in front of experienced professionals.
8	Reflected on how every task across the internship connected back to supporting a stable, well-informed, future-ready workforce.

APPENDIX F — INDICATIVE L&D DASHBOARD REVIEW NOTES

The following notes summarise the structure of the automated Learning & Development dashboard reviewed during Week 6 of the internship, illustrating how training data is organised for management visibility.

Dashboard View	Purpose
Nomination vs Completion Tracker	Shows the proportion of nominated employees who complete assigned training within the target window
Department-wise Training Hours	Summarises average training hours per employee by department, supporting resource-planning decisions
Feedback Score Trends	Tracks post-training feedback ratings over time to flag programmes needing redesign
Mandatory Compliance Training Status	Highlights completion status for statutory or safety-related mandatory training modules

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